Flies in a Weaver's Web

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Mature

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Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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Original Character(s)/Original Character(s)

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Scorpia (She-Ra), Mortella (She-Ra), Original Female Character(s), Original Male Character(s)

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Flies in a Weaver's Web

by tp9829, Zelenal

Summary

Whilst Adora has been taken by the Horde, Halfmoon's spy network deals with their own troubles within the Horde ranks, and when an impossible mission to rescue the missing Knight lands in their lap, it seems like a suicide mission, or is it?

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

- Inspired by Defiance by TheNotebookWizard

Bunkroom 47C

The Main Horde Compound

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Ten Days After Adora's Abduction

It was long after lights out as Blue made her way down the corridor. This was always a risk, but she could not safely get to the secure terminal during the day. Sneaking out past the wandering bots and occasional patrols was a nightmare, but since her promotion to squad leader, it had become slightly easier. Squad Leader Amylin Waters, a decent enough soldier with an unremarkable record, kept intentionally unremarkable to avoid trouble. She went by the alias of Blue to her actual superiors.

Once a month at a random point, she would visit the terminal for any new mission parameters, new orders, and to send off her own reports. It had taken weeks of careful work by Mist to secure that one safe spot to be properly encrypted to send messages to the hidden city with specialist software hidden in its code. Eventually, the software would leak to the rest of the Horde. Tail had made it difficult and was delaying research as much as possible without getting caught but, inevitably, Horde technology would be able to breach the interference; both a curse as it would put the Horde one step closer to victory, and a blessing as it would make tracking messages down to Halfmoon so much harder.

It took her maybe ten minutes of careful manoeuvring to reach the console. Plugging in her identity codes, the software from Halfmoon displayed for a moment. With a standard message, she entered her current report quickly and concisely, written down on a pad of paper, and she would incinerate it with a short blast

from her side arm once she was done. There was one incoming message; new orders beyond just ‘what is happening?’ were rare. She clicked it and a short message appeared on the screen.

IDNTT-Ver: 1.810

Date: [##?##1!##]

Message-ID: [redacted - Classified System]

From: int.om//sec.hlfmn//idntsys - ID: [confirmed]

To: codecomp//hall-12727//indtsys - ID: [confirmed]

Type: Temp Data Request

Class: Text

> Message to be deleted upon being read.

> Halfmoon suffered recent attacks by remnant Dr’Ardeth forces. Need additional movements over known access points to Subtheria in the next report.

> Additional point of interest: Princess Catra’s paramour, known as Adora, captured. Intelligence reveals she has been captured and brought to the Fright Zone. Recovery of Adora is a priority. Additional assets will be provided.

> Please confirm. New priority mission?

> ...

She read the message a few times, memorizing the details. Adora was a name that sounded familiar. It was the name of Shadow Weaver’s missing ward, taken when King Cyrus breached the compound a decade ago. If the Horde had recovered that girl, she would be in the clutches of Shadow Weaver…

This mission went from dangerous to outright impossible in a single message.

> Understood. Current activity report uploading.

She typed out each of the messages on different troop dispositions and trade routes, as well as Mist's list of developments from Horde R&D that he had access to. As she finished typing, she hit send then set her blaster to the lowest setting and incinerated the paper with a quick burst.

Finding Adora was going to be a nightmare. It meant getting close to Shadow Weaver, and Mortella. Those witches had spent years hunting down agents of various factions. She knew that a group of spies spent three weeks under interrogation only to confess to being from Salineas. Their execution was broadcast on the public forum over the lunch period.

She had known as she had spent her own time under interrogation, her distant parentage from Salineas leading Mortella to believe that she could not be trusted. She still had scars under her jaw and along her arms as Vultak did his work and Mortella took her pleasure from her pain. It took every scrap of her strength not to give up the secrets of Halfmoon on that day, but she had endured, and if she never saw another needle in her life, it would be too soon.

She had 'proven her loyalty to the Horde' and been reassigned to squad 47C, a bunch of newly promoted cadets. Too stupid and bought into the propaganda to realize just what the Horde was. Only a single one of them was disillusioned at all towards the Horde, a genius kid who was codenamed Mist for their wispy white hair.

She crept back to the barracks in silence, careful to avoid every potential watcher and in the blind spot of nearly every camera in the Horde, a path that had taken her months to learn. She arrived back at the bunk room a few hours before the daymoon rose, the kids all sleeping soundly. Not one of them were even half her age. Stars Above and Fires Below she was getting too old for this. She would only get a handful of hours of sleep like this but it was better than nothing. She climbed into the

bunk and fell into a deep slumber, with dreams about the Princess' very short stay in the Horde. She had fought that day, and nearly died because of it.

The morning alarm blared to life what felt like seconds after her head hit the mattress. The kids were moving around checking gear and getting ready for the day ahead, Still in the mindset of cadets rather than soldiers. With the current plans it would be waiting, maybe some training. Grumbling as Scatter approached her bunk, she got up and stretched her tired limbs. Hopefully nothing important would happen today and she can just start to plan on how to find this Adora.

The morning passed without comment, standard training routines followed by a watch. The only major thing to note was her squad was up for consideration for reassignment, as were a dozen others to a new facility being constructed by Knight-Captain Leor over one of the entrances to Subtheria. She would make note of that in her next report. The squad leapt into training to try and win that glory; it would be months before the fortress had finished its construction but they wanted to claim that spot.

One advantage of having a fully promoted squad of soldiers rather than a group of cadets was the amount of R&R the group could earn, as long as the standard assigned duties got managed, and basic training standards didn’t fall each squad could spend a bit more time in their barracks or one of the dozen or so recreation rooms across the Fright Zone compound. After training, her squad had split up between the nearest rec room and the barracks until dinner. She needed to formulate a plan, and to get some rest so she slipped back into her bed, not bothering to take off her clothes except for her sergeant's jacket which she slung over a nearby chair.

Both Thasalla and Spike had joined her, sitting on the top of their shared bunk gossiping like cadets about something that she wasn’t paying attention to, while Jolene, Miner, and Scatter had all gone to the rec room. She could feel her eyes drooping and the

weight of the day pressing down on her—one of the kids would wake her for dinner, she was certain—when the door hissed open.

Standing like a ghost in the doorway was a stranger, long seafoam hair tied up in a bun. Her pale blue skin was taut and she had burn marks down her left side recently bandaged. She was wearing a standard issue uniform of a corporal. Reaching under the pillow, Blue gripped the handle of a small knife she kept sheathed underneath. Before she could make any demands, a voice broke the silence of the chambers.

"Mom!" Thalassa was leaping off the topic bunk landing awkwardly in front of the stranger. She rushed into the arms of the woman who dragged her into a hug. "I was so worried, I saw the reports." The woman held her like she was the only thing in the world.

"I'm alright, squirt." The woman's voice was husky, smoke strained either from cigarettes or from the smoke of battle it was impossible to say. "I need to talk to your squad leader for a minute, then we can talk, okay?" She gently tilted Thalassa's chin up and kissed her forehead. The young trooper stepped backwards, smiling like a moonrise.

Thalassa's mother—a rarity to know one's family in the Horde, Thalassa had never spoken of her—sauntered over, she had a sway in her steps that gave off an air of false confidence. Her salute was lazy. "I understand you're my little storm's CO?"

"Sergeant Amylin Waters." Blue responded, standing to her full height and letting the knife rest hidden under the pillow. "Name and rank?" Her words were curt and the woman in front of her flinched slightly at them.

The woman stepped backwards, assessing her with the eyes of wounded prey, trying to gauge whether this was safe harbour or a trap. "Corporal Thala, Third Naval Battalion," her voice contained a barely audible quaver. The Third Naval had been torn apart both by King Mercia's fleet and then by Operation Seahorse.

The whole battalion was rife with spies according to the rumour. “I just got back, and well…” she looked her over “my barracks are now awfully lonely. I need a place to stay.”

Blue could understand that. A lonely and empty barracks would be a nightmare. Nothing about the Fright Zone was ever quiet, save for an empty bed. Horde law with a decimated squad was surprisingly fair: if you could find another squad to take you in, they would accept you until you could properly be reassigned and, if it went well, commanders would try to place you amongst that squad. She was asking to come fight alongside her daughter, to have some comfort from a family. But if she was a spy who had somehow slipped the net, she would be asking for trouble.

She hesitated for a moment, before turning back to look in the room. “Private Thasalla.” The young fishfolks head perked up. “Clear a space for your mother to bunk; she’ll be staying with us for a short while.” The woman in the doorway sagged with relief as if invisible strings had been cut. She signed to her a short *Thank you* as if words had failed her. Thasalla was over helping her mother to an empty bunk in a second.

The woman quickly settled and fell into talking with her daughter and the other members of the squad as they filtered in and out, her eyes kept flicking over to Amlyin appreciatively, whilst the older sergeant slept.

She would have to explain this to her superiors. The part of her that was a squad leader was glad to have another veteran of combat with close ties to the rest of the squad already in place, but the other part of her, the part that had kept her alive as a spy for nearly four decades in the Horde, couldn’t help but feel the paranoia creep up her spine. This woman was as dangerous as she was gorgeous.

It would take three days, in which she could swear there were eyes watching her every move before she could finally calm down enough to make it back to the corridor of 12727 and send off her communication.

IDNTT-Ver: 1.810

Date: [##?##1!##]

Message-ID: [redacted - Classified System]

From: codecomp//hall-12727//indtsys - ID: [confirmed]

To: int.om//sec.hlfmn//idntsys - ID: [confirmed]

Type: Temp Data Request

Class: Text

> Understood, will maintain intelligence on Dr'Ardeth insurgents and agents as they appear in the Horde. Additional movements in Subtheria have been authorized by General Callix. Including 48th, 73rd, and 501st Battalions of Heavy Infantry. Likely to capitalize on the events of last week.

> Mist reports of new weapons development for mass defoliation, detailed schematics as we could gather have been included with the message. Unable to contact Plumerian Spy Network, unsure if it exists with these details.

> Spy network may be temporarily compromised, will go dark for several weeks whilst we determine the threat. If no contact received within 3 months, assume operation lost.

> Additional assets for Operation: Flight of Fancy will be collected at normal drop off at end of second shift rotation four days after this message has been sent. Will send details of our advancements in rescuing the VIP in the next communication.

> Halfmoon Stands, Blue.

>Files Attached: Troop Disposition October 1114.exe, Project: Weedkiller Schematics.PDF

- A Message sent from Sergeant Amilyin Waters codenamed Blue to her commanding officer in Halfmoon Secret Intelligence.

Rec Room 14

The Main Horde Compound

The Fright Zone

Etheria

One Month After Adora's Abduction

The rec rooms were a great place to plan in secret, despite several cameras that dotted every room in the Fright Zone, if you were careful you could stay in their blind spots. The noise of the rooms made planning possible as it covered anything that could be said and picked up by the cameras with the noise of music and laughter.

Blue lounged back on a chair, canteen filled with cool water propped against her knee, while against her side Specialist Amber Regard, codenamed Mist, was rattling off details of Hordak's newest weapons program. A series of advanced bots to be deployed and help with drilling in Subtheria. The woman had an ability to hold detailed reports and specifications in her head, which Amlyin would have to compile into a report that actually made sense to someone in Halfmoon.

"—with the resources from the expansion effort into the mines around Dryl, we should have these bots functional in four to five months. The armour plating is strongest around the drill but weakest around the rotary joints." The woman finished her rambling with the key point which Amlyin was always thankful for.

"Thank you, Amber. This should be everything." She grabbed the canteen and took a long swig, signaling the younger woman

to leave. Instead, she remained seated for a moment, hesitating over something.

"I have to warn you, the penetrator software that is used to send messages, the rollout Fright Zone wide is getting closer. I have introduced some bugs to delay it as long as I can, but by this time next year, we'll need to find a different way to hide our outgoings."

"I was aware. It's a problem for closer to the update time. Until then, we carry on with the procedure." This really wasn't something she could worry about for now. "Was there something else?"

The researcher took a breath. "I may have found out where the VIP is." That got her attention. She leaned forward, pad in hand to take details, gesturing for her to continue. Mist took a breath. "We're getting new transfers from the cadet corp, only a handful, but one of them used to be part of Shadow Weaver's creche. Sweet kid goes by Kyle. I've been assigned to train him in operations for the R&D department. He talked about the Knight of the Fright Zone with such awe like he'd seen her on the propaganda posters but also referred to her by name. Turns out they were crechelings together, bunked together for most of their childhood, all under Shadow Weaver's careful watch."

"Sounds hellish, being raised by that woman." She shuddered at the thought of what those kids had gone through.

"Apparently, their squad was small, only the three of them as permanent members: him, the Knight of the Fright Zone, and a lizardman who goes by Rogelio. The kid talked about them constantly, other members had cycled in and out over the years, but get this." She paused for dramatic effect, taking a sip of her own water. "A decade ago, they had a different squad leader, a blonde haired, grey eyed girl by the name of Adora. Kyle mentioned her in passing and was, and I quote, 'Glad she was back.' That sounds like our Princess' missing girltoy. I asked him what he meant. He said that Shadow Weaver took her somewhere

when she was five and she only showed up again last month, with new scars and she almost immediately was sent to the Dark Temple to train under that assassin who nearly killed Hordak a few years ago."

"Fuck."

"Yeah, fuck, this is way beyond our abilities, Lin, way beyond sending troop movements and schematics. This is a fucking shit show." The woman leaned back, and Amliyin took another long swig of her growing tepid water.

"We'll need way more time to plan this. We've got nobody in the Dark Temple; we know next to nothing about it. If the VIP, this Adora, is under the attention of both Shadow Weaver and Knight-Captain Lonnie then this is a suicide mission. I can't risk us on it. I'll push back on command until I can get further clarification."

"There was something else that may help us: I got some of the names from Operation Sea Horse." She froze at that. "One of them was in the Dark Temple."

"How the fuck did Salineas manage to get a spy into the Dark Temple?" she hissed out. "It doesn't matter, it obviously didn't work, they're all dead and captured now." The traitors that were captured were only taken down last week after hanging for over a month at the edge of the Fright Zone as a warning to people like the two of them not to betray the Horde.

"What if they weren't?" the younger woman pressed on, ignoring her discomfort about the subject. She still had scars running up and down the length of her body from Vultak's interrogation when she was a suspect, she had nearly screamed out the secrets of Halfmoon then and there. "At least two agents have escaped capture, their codenames are the only thing that Horde Counterintelligence knows. 'Timber' and 'Hold' both of which escaped capture." Her thoughts drifted back to the woman

now sleeping one bunk away from her, looking desperate. Would she look the same if this whole operation came tumbling down?

"I'll look into it, see if I can figure anything out. But anyone working for any of the other kingdoms is going to be spooked, fuck knows I am at this point." She tried to keep her voice level and calm. "Keep talking to this Kyle. See if he spills any more details about the Knight Captain or the VIP. Anything will be useful, I'll add what we know now to this report." Amber nodded once and stood up. Picking up the spare grey ration bar that Amlyin left for her, she left the room in a brisk stride to return to her own bunk room.

Amliyin leaned back and sighed, wishing at this moment she had some moonleaf to take the edge off. The last month had been a nightmare and it was only going to get worse. She had barely survived a few minutes in the sharks cage of Horde Counterintelligence's ire, now she was going to have to dive back in unprotected.

She picked up the stylus and began to compose her report.

Salutations, Illustrious Host.

I hope this letter finds you in good health. I am afraid I have suffered greatly, the ship of the fleet was sunk by vicious pirates and the whole crew lost to the inky depths, may King Mercia bless their souls for their bravery. They were sunk by both a far too inquisitive pirate fleet that surrounds my ships as they sail and the Kraken that ventures far into the waters of the Growling Sea. I fear it may attack other ships of various merchant captains.

The many souls lost have sent my brother into grieving and he will return home to Salineas at the earliest convenience. I hope you treat him well for my sake, he has had a most difficult time. While I myself would love to make the journey, I am afraid I cannot leave my child who is in a most vulnerable state, falling in love with a peasant here in Plumeria. She has foolish notions but

what can a parent do but be there for them. I will remain close by her side until such time as I can find new friends.

I hope to make acquaintance with a colleague from the court of Queen Angella before the next harvest. Perhaps they can entertain me and help with the shipping situation.

Clear Skies and Strong Sails,

Lady Mahullard.

-A coded letter sent to Salineas via Plumeria origin point of the Fright Zone, given to Salineas' Head of Secret Intelligence.

Quartermaster's Office

The Main Horde Compound

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Three Month After Adora's Abduction

The backrooms of the warehouse were always an absolute mess, almost by design from years of cadets breaking in to steal what they needed, negligent quartermasters, and the hustle of active campaigns. The place was almost never monitored unless the top brass came through which meant it was the perfect spot for Reserve Captain Sage Breaker, codenamed 'Azure' by her contact, to meet with her cohorts, what few were left of her cell that hadn't fled in fear from Shade.

All four members of her cell were crammed into the small office, each having a valid reason to visit the Quartermaster. She was reading through what reports they had gathered. She had a direct line to Netossa to send her reports. She had spent the last week working out the added supply lines and the purpose of

various requisition forms, something was being planned in Plumeria that would take years to come to fruition but these early requests indicated a full forward base would be developed. Callix had sent in dozens of requisitions for specialized armour and additional lamp packs, the kind of gear that would be required in Subtheria, what he could be fighting down there she could only guess. She had included her guesses in the report.

Sergeant Jisea Ararch, codenamed 'Rose,' was a scorpioni woman who served in the Hordes heavy infantry. Her armour was cracked in the fighting and she had taken the excuse to search for a replacement to make her report on the morale of the troops and the disposition of troops in the field along the Whispering Woods front. Her reports were always concise and accurate. The huge woman was cramped down into a chair, reading glasses fixed firmly on her face below her shock of distinctive red hair that matched her carapace.

Sergeant Raccal Viren, codenamed 'Cyan,' was a slight fae man, and one of the top gunners of the third tank battalion. He had been involved in dozens of battles and his loyalty to the Horde was assured. His reports to Netossa had saved countless lives by allowing the surreptitious evacuation of towns in the path of Horde attacks. Viren was a calculating individual weighing the pros and cons of every decision and, like everyone in the room, was a hardened killer which made his small stature and elegant butterfly wings the perfect deception. His current reports on upcoming assaults by Force Captain Grizzlor's force would spare many lives in the coming months.

Finally was the faun woman Ample Moonless, codenamed 'Magenta.' Her technical rank was private as she was a complete cover, a Mystacoran mage who maintained several illusions to disguise herself. Her goals in the Horde all revolved around the rogue witch Shadow Weaver, known in the reports as Shade. She had made several inroads into getting access to Shadow Weaver's personal house of horrors, the Dark Temple, but progress was slow though her newest bit of intel was interesting. A missing recruit supposedly hidden away by Shadow Weaver for a decade

had returned and began tutelage under the assassin that Sage had helped break in several years ago. The girl had a huge reserve of celestial magic and was a near rival for the Knight, which put her better than any champion in the Horde and most Knights of Bright Moon.

The four of them all handed her their current reports to cross reference information to send across to Netossa. After a few minutes of silence only broken by the shuffling noise of paper and scribbled amendments, Viren spoke up. “We need to address the skiff in the room.” His voice was quiet and calm. “The Salinean contingent has been wiped out; any information they had is gone. The longer we stick around, the greater the chance we’ll be caught by Shade as well. We need a plan to keep this operation going. Any suggestions?”

He was met with a series of groans. Everyone was aware of the dangers of Hordak’s personal group of torturers and interrogators who would drag secrets out of everyone around them. No one had a good plan beyond scattering if Horde intelligence found them. Each had organized their own route out of the Fright Zone and kept it secret from the others. After a moment of silence, he let out a long breath. “Until the next meeting then?”

Sage looked up from the collected notes and stared at the group of them. “We still have a massive blind spot: not a single one of us knows what's happening in Hordak’s labs. We need someone with access to R&D, otherwise everything we send is just guess work. We know that the Salineans had at least one agent in both R&D and the Dark Temple.” Moonless sneered at that for a moment, then resumed her calm expression. “But with them eliminated, we need a new source of intel. Think about it before the next meeting. Dismissed, and don’t forget to grab what you were looking for on the way out.” Everyone stalked out of the room at different times, not wanting to be seen together, until it was only Sage and Moonless.

The sorceress approached her slowly. “I didn’t want to say anything in front of the others—you can never be too careful—but I believe there is a third party spying on the Horde. I cannot say who they are, whether they are another cell working for Bright Moon, a group that survived Operation Sea Horse, or a third party—my best guess would be Snows—but they are active. Someone has been breaching my late night alarm around a terminal in corridor 12727. I checked it out, and while at first it appears to be ordinary, a little digging shows software I couldn’t get access to but could have been crafted in a laboratory. Either the Fright Zone’s Research Department, or any laboratory of our sponsors with sufficient computer equipment and some old Horde operating systems, but I know it isn’t Salinean. I can leave a message for whoever made it via… arcane means, asking for a meeting?”

Sage listened to all of this quietly. “You didn’t bring it up in front of the others?”

The older woman nodded. “Call me paranoid, but I fear the more we share, the less we hold. I will keep this meeting between me and you until we can be certain of the others’ intentions.” Whether she meant this third party or the others in her cell, it was difficult to say.

“Do it. We set a meeting. Not too soon, give me some time to figure out who they are at least. A few weeks away, maybe.”

The sorceress nodded once before leaving the chamber. Sage sat down and began to fill out the letter. Hand-delivered notes to Bright Moon were difficult but the most secure form, especially with a carefully made seal that could only be broken by the master of spies back in the Shining City.

To the crafter of the software found in security console 12727:

I bid you greetings. I apologize that we are unable to speak face to face at this moment, but would like to encourage a meeting so that we may share in mutual aid. I understand the

need for caution but occasionally risks must be taken; I ask you to think of how a sorcerer with access to knowledge far beyond others may assist you, and how you may assist me.

I ask that we meet face to face. I shall bring myself and a comrade-in-arms, you and one of your own comrades and together we may discuss what we know. This letter is incriminating enough for the both of us, so I hope you will trust me.

If you wish to respond, please write a brief message on the back of this letter. Once you are done, burn it, and I shall hear what you have to say.

Kind regards,

Magenta

- A Message left on the desk of Researcher Amber Regard one month after the previous meeting.

Okay, three days time, Horror Hall one hour after lights out. If we see more than two people, we shoot.

Mist

- A response written on the back of that note before the note was burnt.

Horror Hall

The Main Horde Compound

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Four Month After Adora's Abduction

Horror Hall more than lived up to its name, the large imposing stone structure standing out against the dark green metals of the Fright Zone. Once the grand hall of the Scorpioni now reduced to a curiosity. It was a grand old ruin. Both Sage and Ample sat under a large stained glass window of the last Emperor of the Nest. A fitting symbol for the madness of their plan, exposing one cell of spies to another was a recipe for disaster. She had to hope though, that maybe this time it wouldn't result in all the deaths that working with Salineas had brought.

The two of them sat quietly, waiting patiently. After maybe an hour sat in the halflight of the hall, illuminated only by the outer lighting shining through stained glass, two figures appeared in the doorway. Both were armed and wearing uniforms including full face helmets.

They approached cautiously, hands hovering over their stun batons. "Identify yourselves." A gruff female voice called from beneath the taller of the two helmets.

Sage stood up, hands raised in surrender. "My name is Azure," she gestured with a nod at Ample still sitting on the floor, "this is Magenta. I assume one of you was responsible for the terminal in 12727?"

The shorter of the two tilted their head towards the taller one. "You left a message wanting a meeting. Why?" the same woman's voice spoke. Sage turned her head to look down at Ample; this was her plan after all. Ample opened her hands showing her palms in a *It's up to you what you tell them* gesture.

"We represent interests beyond the Fright Zone, and based on what my colleague saw when she went to access that terminal, we think you may be as well." The other two looked at each other, shock visible even under their face masks. "I'll take that as a yes," she said smugly. The shorter of the two removed their helmet first revealing a short haired, brown eyed woman. Then the taller one removed her helmet to show a hardened-looking woman, blue

hair going grey at the roots and a nose that had been broken several times.

The blue haired woman gestured to the shorter woman. "This is Mist, I am Blue. Now that pleasantries are over with, what do you want?" She looked over at Magenta and took a deep breath. At least some of their cards were on the table.

"My friend here is a sorcerer. We have spent a huge amount of resources infiltrating the Black Temple to gain more information on Shadow Weaver, codenamed Shade in our dossier. However, with everything that happened with the Salinean agents earlier this year," she paused to gauge their reaction. There was definitely a slightly raised eyebrow. They knew. "We have had to postpone intel gathering in the Black Temple."

"Your friend, but not you?" the shorter woman said. "Magenta was the name left on my desk, with the telltale stink of magic all over it. But Azure didn't come up."

"If we are to have cooperation, I'll be your main point of contact," she locked eyes with this Blue, "and you'll be mine I suppose." The woman nodded her head a fraction.

"If," she said, then the shorter woman grabbed her arm and led 'Blue' slightly backwards. The two had a muttered conversation, but the only thing that Azure could pick up was the distinctive words 'Mystacor' then a few more seconds of animated conversation. Then they turned back. "You still haven't answered my question: what do you want?"

She took a calm breath. "We need as broad access as possible." She looked over at Mist. "You work in Research and Development, getting any intel from there may change the war."

Mist's eyes went wide and she looked over at the older woman on her right, who kept a calm demeanour. Who was she spying for? Snows? A Salinean agent from another cell? Even another Bright Moon agent? It was impossible to know.

“And what do we get out of this?”

“What intel we have gathered from the Dark Temple, and any movements that wouldn’t compromise our employer’s plans.”

The woman looked down at her hands for a moment and muttered something under her breath. She suddenly looked exhausted. But when she looked back, there was a grim determination that had settled over her features. “If we are going to do this, know that we cannot trust each other. I cannot afford to trust you.”

Azure nodded; that made sense, she didn’t trust this woman, not completely.

“But we have been given a task that I thought impossible, but if you have the knowledge you claim, perhaps it can be done.” Azure raised an eyebrow at that and Magenta stood to her full height, walking over to join her commander. Azure gestured for her to continue.

“There is a new recruit for the Horde’s champion program. A blonde girl can’t be older than 16, she was recently brought to the Black Temple. I have been tasked with recovering her by any means necessary. It’s being referred to as Operation: Flight of Fancy.”

Azure snorted and Magenta made a small gasping sound before speaking, “I know the girl you speak of, she is a close confidant of Shadow Weaver. If you agree to help, I shall endeavour to learn more for our next meeting.” Azure looked at her then turned back to Blue, holding out a hand.

After a moment's hesitation, Blue took it. “I sure hope I’m not fucking this up,” she said between them. The feeling was completely mutual.

To Netossa,

Enclosed in this letter is the report for this month. I hope it serves you well. We have made contact with another group of infiltrators from the Kingdom of Snows within the Horde with access to further details from other departments. We have agreed to mutual cooperation, within reason.

If you do not receive another letter within the month, assume we have been compromised by this decision. I apologize for risks taken, but not for taking them.

I hope this letter finds you and your wife well.

Magenta

Storage Closet 113#A

The Main Horde Compound

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Six Month After Adora's Abduction

The small storage closet was cramped, dark, and full of dust, but it had no camera's which meant when it was just the two of them, Blue could afford to have her meetings with Specialist Sharps Fort—codenamed 'Tails'—in some measure of privacy. He had recently returned from the frontlines and spent the last month in medical getting various surgeries.

He had made it out better than most. His squad had run into a Rebellion ambush led by the Scourge and involving the Mad Sorceress of Mystacor. Most of the squad hadn't come back at all. His wounds were deep, nearly being disembowelled by a master swordswoman had left him unable to be redeployed for months.

She had filled him in with all the details he had missed on his last few months of deployment as soon as possible, including Operation: Flight of Fancy, which was why they were meeting today. He had grabbed her and dragged her to the closest, which was between their two squads' bunks. When the two of them were alone, he let out a long sigh.

"I grabbed something, fuck it was stupid." He started reaching into a bag he carried on his shoulder. "But you mentioned the operation and we needed all the details we could get." He came out holding a file, standard issue and quite thick. Someone's medical records? He shoved it into her hands. "I am not sure I got away perfectly, so keep it hidden. I have been authorised temporary leave but with regular check ups. If anyone asks, this wasn't more than a chance meeting. Don't take any stupid risks with it!" He stepped out of the closet leaning against the wall, grunting in pain. Out of her sight before she could say anything, his paranoia had kept him alive for a decade in the Horde.

She looked down at the file, simply labeled Cadet #2894. She opened it, her eyes adjusting to the dim light of the chamber. Inside was a picture of the VIP, Adora, no surname listed. Simply a Cadet Number, a medical picture, and a note. Her species was listed as unknown—that was a curiosity. She thumbed through the pages, and there it was, her last medical check up was the day of the attack on the Fright Zone by King Cyrus, and then nothing, a jump of a decade until six months ago, when Vultak was given permission to examine her again, listing most of these not as full notes but as conjecture. This would be useful, if she could get the rest of the picture by sending this off and asking for clarification. It would show actual progress in her work. She stepped out into the corridor, shoving the folder into the folds of her uniform jacket.

Tails had taken a huge risk in this, one that if discovered would get them all killed but he more than anyone had understood the importance of the mission. His family had been Magicats, cut off from Halfmoon and living in one of the small towns along the border. His parents were now long dead. When it

was explained that the VIP was a heartbond, he became much more serious than anyone else about achieving this goal.

She looked around the corridor, checking Tails had gone before turning back to her dorm. As she walked, she stepped out into Corridor 12727 and saw a medic standing at the terminal. Her heart skipped a beat as she watched him access the code. She recognised him, a torturer who worked directly for Mortella. He had her in his clutches for three days less than a year ago. The scars still itched. Medical Officer Vandel. He worked with Horde Counterintelligence.

She tried to stop herself from staring but she could still feel his needles and blades on her skin. Her chest tightened for a moment, broken only by him slamming a hand into the terminal with a shouted expletive. He turned suddenly to look at her, nostrils flared in anger, before a sudden serene calm overcame him. She recognised that look. The sudden urge to vomit filled her.

His voice was nasally, like his nose had been broken several times and never properly healed over, "Ah… Sergeant Breaker, it has been too long since you came by for a… check up." She shuddered. They were technically of equal rank but his position in Mortella and Vultak's favour put him above her; she didn't salute anyway. He ignored the slight and continued. "It seems this terminal is having some difficulties with its operations. Be a good grunt and contact IT, have someone come and look at it. It's your normal terminal is it not?"

Sweat ran down her spine; through years of training she kept her voice steady as she said sharply, "Yes, sir. I will get someone on it." She went to turn away.

"Oh, Sergeant, make sure they check the cameras as well. It seems someone has been tampering with them." She froze there, turning back with a quick salute.

"Of course, sir. I am sure you can get to the bottom of it, sir." He smiled up at her—she was a head taller than him, but he somehow loomed over her.

"Dismissed, Sergeant. Return to your squad and get someone down here. I will be down to check tomorrow morning." He waved her away. Only when she was around the corner and out of his sight did she let out a shaky sob. They would have to find another way to contact Halfmoon. She made it back to the barracks and asked Scatter to handle the job.

With shaking hands, she opened the medical file on Adora, and began to read. She could memorize these details and try to slip it back into Medical, hopefully with no one noticing. Trying to find another means of contact with Halfmoon just became their top priority.

>Horde.net Data Point, Entry Medical Terminal #4

>Horde.net Data Point, Reception Dark Temple Terminal #7

>Concerning the suspicions of 12727

>From Agent Kukri

>To Agent Mortal

>Ident codes confirmed.

>Your suspicions have been confirmed, my lady. Whoever had access to the terminal in 12727 has access to the internal operating system, which indicates a deep penetration of our security. Likely another cell. I was unable to save any messages from the terminal before it deleted all the contents. I have passed the hard drive to loyal agents in the R&D department, specialists I have personally secured the loyalty of. If anything is left to be recovered, we shall find it, but I fear it is a dead end.

>As I am currently unable to ascertain the identities of this cell. I am requesting that Kalis be reassigned to assist my investigation, his work on Operation: Seahorse proves our joint efficacy.

>If I were to make an educated guess, I would say this group, if it is a group and not a lone operative, works for Bright Moon. Your agents in Snows would have discovered something by now. If I am wrong, I would ask to be looped in.

>If anyone is captured, I will bring them directly to you. I apologize once again for leaving you out of the fun with the Salineans. I shall not make that mistake again. Inspector must be kept in the loop, but I shall keep him from this for as long as possible.

Horror Hall

The Main Horde Compound

The Fright Zone

Etheria

One Year After Adora's Abduction

It had taken months for Blue and Mist to come up with an adequate solution to the 'Contact Halfmoon' problem. Eventually, Mist had managed to push through an updated version of the Horde radio system alongside the help of Kyle, who it turns out was both willing to talk about the Knight Captain and the VIP at length, and was a technical genius. Between Mist and Kyle, the two had gotten a much stronger radio connection down into Halfmoon that would be tested later today at the Knight Captain's insistence.

With the prototypes in hand, they reestablished contact after a six month drop, with a quick report of the goings on of the

Horde and that more would follow when it was safe. Espionage was a slow and methodical game, occasionally interrupted by quick bursts of maddening activity. Soon, contact could be managed via any terminal and a hidden piece of software that only she and Mist had access to. If either of them got caught with it then it would spell their doom but it was better than fumbling in the dark.

The two of them sat now in Horror Hall for their monthly meeting with the Bright Moon spy network. Agent Magenta had appeared and, after a brief talk, the sharing of information had begun. What scraps of details, information on the new Horde operating system and its weakpoints—leaving out the backdoor into the Halfmoon communication of course—was useful for the spymaster of Bright Moon. While she had offered to move letters out of the Horde to a potential courier when she had overheard them talking about their difficulty with contacting their employer, a nice and unsubtle attempt at discovering who they worked for.

"Thank you but no, we've managed to sort ourselves out just fine." She tried to sound grateful despite the probing questions. "Now that we are back in operation, we can focus on further plans from Research and Development." The other woman, Azure, at first seemed offended by the rebuttal before taking the file proffered to her and reading it over.

"New armour for the heavy tanks and for champions made of irdo… Inid—"

"Indorium" Blue corrected casually. "It's an alloy of several ores mined in Subtheria. Resistant to magic and incredibly rare outside of it."

"That explains Calix." Azure kept reading through the notes.

"What about Calix?" She asked, suddenly worried. The stone general was a constant threat and one of the better tactical officers at the Horde's disposal.

"He's taken down a whole army into Subtheria: a scout company, three heavy armoured units, and two companies of heavy infantry alongside the new drilling bots. It's listed on page six." Azure flipped to the next page, commenting on the potential destruction of their unknown ally as if it was the latest troop disposition, which to her it was.

She steeled herself; do not show any emotions, showing emotion is weakness. "Alright, I'll add it to my report. Anything else of note?"

Blue sighed and looked her dead in the eye. "This would go a lot quicker if we had more frequent meetings or we could bring more agents to compile this. I understand the risks but we're moving too slowly. My employer is trying to get more and more out of me, and your employer must be just as desperate."

That was true, Halfmoon intelligence was always desperate for answers. Any scrap of information could prove vital in saving the city from its destruction. She leaned back, running one hand through her hair, more grey hairs seemingly every morning from the stress of this job.

"No, we can't take the risk. I trust you, barely, but I do. Not enough to reveal any more than I have to, and I hope I have earnt that same amount of trust."

"You have, but?"

"But my trust does not extend to the rest of your cell, as your trust for me shouldn't extend to mine. If either side gets compromised, I want only one of us to fall." She grimaced. "We've both had run-ins with Darkney's men before. I would not like a repeat from a stupid mistake one of us could make."

She could tell she had landed a successful blow, this argument always went this way the three times they had it in the past. "Okay," Azure said, "but Magenta wants to organize another

meeting, and I do at some point want to know who I am helping. You know my loyalties, I should know yours."

"I think I know your loyalties, but how sure can I be?" She shrugged. "Darkney or Mortella could have gotten to you or any of your people. Bright Moon is far away and they are only a short walk away."

The woman snarled at her. "I would die before betraying Bright Moon."

"Good, then let's not test that theory by taking unnecessary risks. Page seven may interest you. It's about the new operating system and some weak points that may intercept radio broadcasts."

They fell back into the comfortable silence between them. Despite the differing allegiances and the secrets kept, the two worked well together. For several minutes, they sat reading through the notes they handed each other, making their own copies.

Azure broke the silence as she began to pack away her own notes into a carefully hidden seam of a belt bag. "If they get this production underway, of the indorium I mean, a magic resistant metal on tanks and champions would wreck havoc on our forces."

She looked up at the woman. "Are you suggesting we do something?"

The other woman shrugged. "Sabotage is not outside my job description, I am just… fuck, sometimes I feel useless. This war has ground to an absolute halt and we are just sitting here sending off forms. If we could stop this from happening, at least I'll be doing something."

Blue put the papers down, she had memorised what she needed anyway. "This would be incredibly risky; we don't have any details yet of where or how they are going to refine it or

when it will be sent out. This could be years away yet. The patient hunter gets the prey."

"I suppose you're correct. Once we know more, though, I'll come back to you with an actual plan. I have asked Magenta to keep an eye out for your VIP. Wherever Shadow Weaver is keeping her, it's beyond our ability to reach."

"Alright, keep looking I suppose. Thank you for the help. We are making a difference. I know it doesn't feel like it, but so many more would be dead without our respective efforts." She reached out and put a hand on the younger woman's shoulder and held eye contact. "All this will be worth it. Find your strength and never let it go, and we'll win in the end. I promise." The last bit came out like a prayer, and in a way it was, the old Celestial Promise prayer still rang out in her mind despite five decades of separation.

The other woman looked at her, and then nodded with a muttered "Okay." The two of them parted ways, they would meet again at the same time next month, and the argument would surely repeat.

IDNTT-Ver: 1.810

Date: [##?##1!##]

Message-ID: [redacted - Classified System]

From: int.om//sec.hlfmn//idntsys - ID: [confirmed]

To: codecomp//sec-42s//indtsys - ID: [confirmed]

Type: Temp Data Request

Class: Text

>Thank you for the recent data. We have managed to drive back Calix's forces, but not without risk. Recent assets acquired

require verification of details and may aid in Operation: Flight of Fancy.

>At the request of the Crown Princess an interrogation of one of the captured prisoners was made. Details of the interrogation are found attached. Please confirm as many of the details as possible.

>The subject claimed familiarity with the VIP, with details confirmed by the Crown Princess. We ask if at all possible to increase the importance of Operation: Flight of Fancy.

>Please confirm the below details and what assets will be required for an extraction attempt to be made. This order has been signed over by King Cyrus. So top priority.

>Attached: TranscriptOfSergeantRogelioInterrogation.txt

Quartermaster's Office

The Main Horde Compound

The Fright Zone

Etheria

One Year and Eight Months After Adora's Abduction

It was a tough few weeks: several of their messages had been intercepted or were flat out wrong. Azure trusted her sources so there was a breach somewhere. She was working her normal job as a quartermaster when she spotted her.

Blue, her contact, had come to the Quartermaster's office to requisition new power cells for her squad. She finally could see her actual name, Sergeant Amylin Waters, an incredibly Salinean name. Perhaps she was from another cell of Salineas that had survived. The two had made eye contact and had pretended like

nothing had happened at first, after all they were not alone, but she would need to grab Blue and tell her about the data breach.

A tall scorpioni Force Captain was moving around the room, staring at articles of clothing way too small for her and muttering under her breath. Which looked like her chance, she gestured over for Blue to join her.

The woman picked out several items and joined her, keeping up appearances. The two entered the back storage room. As the door closed, she turned on her.

"We have a breach!" panic in her tone. "I don't know where, but if it's from us then I have no idea, and if it's from you…" she trailed off.

The older woman scowled at her. "Alright, calm down. This is important, but it's too risky to just grab me when you spot me. This will have to wait for our next meeting. Now I am going to leave, you're going to follow me out after a minute."

She nodded and Blue turned around exiting the small storage room. As she stepped out a minute later, she spotted Blue standing by the exit holding some batteries, and the Scorpioni Force Captain was still there now holding what appeared to be Etherian style bracers in her hands—the kind worn by swordsmen from Bright Moon—and a newcomer to the room.

A tall orc with grey skin but far leaner than the average orc. He had a long knife strapped to his belt, beyond standard issue, and a compact rifle slung on his back. His armour was a dense layered patchwork of dark metals and on the collar was a single gem, like a dark amethyst—a Shard of the Black Garnet—marking him out as a champion of the Horde.

He approached her, presenting the gemstone to show his authority. "I am Champion Mortis. I have some questions for you." His voice was low and grating. "You will answer me truthly. Do that and I will be on my way. Lie to me and I have the authority

to bring you to Mortella for further questions.” He held the S on questions like a serpent’s hiss.

She gave a quick salute. “Of course, Champion.”

“You authorize all mechanical maintenance in hallways one thousand through two thousand five hundred, correct?”

“Yes, sir.”

“Are you aware of a fault reported a few months ago on terminal twelve thousand seven hundred twenty seven?”

“I… I get hundreds of requests for maintenance a month, sir.”

“Yes or no, Specialist?” His tone indicated he wouldn’t ask again.

“I don’t recall that particular terminal, sir.” Over his shoulder, she saw Blue stiffen. Was this something to do with their operation failure a few months ago?

“Hmm, a shame. Is your loyalty to the Horde absolute?”

“Yes, sir.”

“Tell me do you know this woman?” he held up a file showing the face of Ample. She fought incredibly hard to keep any surprise from showing up on her face.

“In passing, sir.” Do not lie directly; half truths.

“Elaborate.”

“We shared a deployment once when I was active duty, and shared water rations once. We had a brief… intimate moment, but broke it off soon after. I never got her full name and rank, just that we were physically attracted to one another." *Please chalk this up to embarrassment.*

He clicked his tongue at that. “If you are to see her again, please inform your nearest Force Captain. She is wanted for crimes against the Horde.” *Fuck.* “Back to the terminal, has anyone made a request for any of the following in the last six months?” He slid across a requisition form with several items filled in. *Tablets, extra lamp packs, explosives?*

“Sir, this list is some of the most commonly requisitioned items in the Horde.”

He chuckled. “Then I would like a list of everyone who has asked for these items more than once in the last year.”

“Sir, that’s an unreasonable request.” He hissed at her.

“Alright that's enough!” The Scorpioni stood up, to her full height. “You can get all that from the terminal, she’s clearly a busy woman, and I don’t like to hear you threatening people, Ash.”

The orc turned to look at the woman who towered over him. “My apologies, Princess, but this has to be handled.”

“Then handle it elsewhere. I have no time to keep an eye on you and stop you from going around threatening hard working people.” Her pincers clicked. He stared at her, weighing up his chances in a fight no doubt.

“Very well, do not bother with the list, Specialist.” He was speaking to her despite his eyes never leaving the threatening woman. “But please, find me the details of that terminal and have it on my desk by tomorrow morning.” He left the room in a few strides, as quiet as a ghost.

The Scorpioni watched him go, then turned to her. “Are you alright? Sorry about that, us champions tend to get far too big for our britches and start bossing people around. Really gets on my nerves.”

“It’s alright, ma’am.” She let out a shaky breath. Blue looked about ready to collapse.

“Oh, no, I’m not a ma’am, please call me Scorpia.” She held out one long pincer. Gingerly, she took it and shook. “Now, I am trying to get something for a friend, she needs some bracers and I don’t know if these are right?”

“You said you were a champion ma—Scorpia?”

“Oh yeah. Me, Lonnie, and Adora are all working away at the Dark Temple’s *tenemos.”*

Oh…

>Horde.net Data Point, Entry Hallway Terminal #10034

>Horde.net Data Point, Reception Command Terminal #18

>Concerning Operation: Midnight

>From: Agent Kris

>Receipt: Inspector

>Ident Codes confirmed.

>Inspector, you were completely correct. The spy network runs deep. I have taken great lengths of time without communicating to ensure trust. I have recently become aware of a second unknown cell within the Horde’s ranks working for an unknown third party. The group I have successfully infiltrated are loyal to Bright Moon.

>In the attached file, I have included a dossier of each of the members. Some details are missing as the paranoia has kept them from giving more than simple descriptions and off meetings, but I know each code name, squad markings, and an adequate description of each.

>How do you wish to proceed?

>Attached files: Azure.docx, Cyan.docx, Rose.docx, Magenta.docx

Horror Hall

The Main Horde Compound

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Two Years After Adora's Abduction

The two of them sat in silence, their window of opportunity was slowly closing. In her hands, Azure held the last message delivered by magic in the event of her death. Magenta had left a final detailed report. Shadow Weaver had captured her, tortured her, and then executed her as a traitor to the Horde. Too dangerous to let a sorcerer who knew Horde secrets loose even onto Beast Island.

The note had been specific in its details. Moonless had let the message be delivered to Blue and not Azure as a final act of trust. The woman had become convinced that they had been compromised, and with how she was captured that was likely true, justifying everything that she had told Azure multiple times. The note had detailed facts about Adora that were known to only Shadow Weaver. The girl had a near infinite well of celestial magic, she was born on another world, she had some connection that tethered her in a way nothing else could, all laced in sorcerer speak. Blue could decode most of it, and the rest, well Shadow Weavers plans were always stomach churning.

She had read it and then handed it to Azure who had read the whole thing as well. Then she pulled out a bottle of something

that smelled and tasted foul, but pulled her nerves back under in a wave of cheap moonshine.

"If this is true," Azure started, "then your mission just became our top priority as well, no matter what Netossa says."

"Two years, I've had two fucking years to plan this extraction, it's impossible, it's not even a suicide mission, it just can't be done." Blue took another swig of the cheap booze, the burn matching the feeling in her chest.

"You're right. Getting into the Dark Temple seems impossible, and she doesn't have a scheduled time she leaves except for these nights in 'The Tomb,' whatever that means, but it's under Shadow Weavers supervision. What do we know?"

She handed back the bottle. If they were going to do this, she could at least afford to be open with this woman who was risking her life even being here. She may already be a dead woman if the betrayal ran deep enough. "We have someone who knows her personally: an R&D tech called Kyle. The Scorpioni Princess also seems fond of her. You can't approach either of them though, not without arousing suspicion."

"I'll find a way to talk to the Princess. If I can find her and get a few minutes alone or I can get Tails to do it, he has always been better at finding people than me. Mist can talk to Kyle, see what he knows or is willing to do. One major problem though: all three of them are close to the Knight."

The woman took a long swig. "Well, it's suicide either way." She paused to look at Blue intensely. "What if we went back to the plan from last year?"

"Last year's plan?"

"With the indorium. We now know where in the forge it's being produced, and the generators are close by. Get enough explosives together and we can blow the thing sky high, which will definitely cause a distraction. If we get Scorpia on board, she might be able

to grab Adora and run." It wasn't the worst plan. Actually, it was an atrocious plan. But they had nothing else. In two years, it was the best plan they could come up with.

She held out a hand for the bottle and took a long swig of the last dregs. "Alright, we're almost certainly going to die, but let's make the Horde bleed for it. I'll get the others in. Then we attack."

When the alarms sounded the next morning, Azure awoke with a pounding headache, but set about her day as normal. She kept a look out for her throughout the day. It was only towards the afternoon that she spotted the woman doing laps of the foundry.

She gestured and the woman looked surprised but came over. "I know you don't know who I am," she said quickly, "but I am going to risk my life by talking to you."

The woman frowned. "Why would talking to me risk your life?"

"I am a friend of Adora," she started, the woman looked ready to interrupt, "she will not remember me because of Shadow Weaver. You know what she did to her."

Scorpia's jaw clicked shut audibly.

"I am trying to find a path to free her, and it is damn near impossible without your help. So please, Princess Scorpia." the woman recoiled slightly at the honourific. An insult in the Horde but a blessing everywhere else. "Help me save her."

"Adora is stubborn," the woman settled on saying. "She doesn't want to leave…" her voice trailed off.

"If she doesn't, she will suffer more, and more. You know Shadow Weaver does not care for her."

"I… I shouldn't be talking to you."

“Scorpia, please, I have seen what Shadow Weaver plans, Adora should go home, be with her family.” A look passed over the other woman's face of shock.

“You know where Adora is from?”

“Partially. I don’t have all the details, but she has people who miss her. Isn’t that enough?”

“What’s your plan? I won’t promise anything. But I’ll hear you out.”

Blue took a steadying breath, and explained the need for a distraction, the potential explosives that could be detonated around the forge to create a distraction, that she could organize an attack if necessary, but she needed someone close to get Adora out of the Dark Temple and to key Adora in on the plan.

“I can’t do that. Whatever Shadow Weaver did to her, it runs deep.” That was the answer Blue feared more than anything. “But, I can get you those explosives. No one looks too hard at a Force Captain’s requisitions, and I know someone dying to build a bomb and break out.”

“Who?”

“Duncan, he’s teaching Adora. The man can make enough bombs to blow the forge completely.”

“The Assassin!” she almost shouted but caught herself. She had heard the rumours, he had almost overwhelmed Shadow Weaver and Hordak, and was only stopped by the Knight’s first mission. If he was on their side, maybe this could work.

“Yeah, I can convince him. In fact, he mostly convinced me already. It may take a while but I’ll get you that distraction.”

Agent,

As we are unsure of the current Horde intelligence, I am going against protocol to have this delivered through riskier channels. Our intelligentsia have been occupied trying to get some contact from the other kingdoms to gather supplies and unable to issue any orders to you.

Halfmoon has been struck by a deadly plague. We are fairly certain the Horde is responsible. Please investigate as best you can and report any findings through the usual channels. We need to be assured that this kind of biological attack cannot be repeated.

Attempts will be made shortly to steal medical supplies. Do what you can to get supplies diverted down to Subtheria to aid us in acquiring them. I do not care how you do it but get it done.

This is a new top priority over Operation: Flight of Fancy (I am still annoyed by this name.)

Signed Crown Princess and Acting Regent Catra Dr'illuth.

P.S. Updates on Operation: Flight of Fancy would be appreciated.

- *A coded missive to be hand delivered to Agent Blue. Never received.*

Bunkroom 47C

The Main Horde Compound

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Two-and-a-Half Years After Adora's Abduction

One final message, the thought kept ringing in the back of her head like a siren. No more reports, no more drills and

sneaking out. This would be her final report. Halfmoon would know, and act. She wouldn't live to see the next report. She had spent all morning coming to terms with that fact, still tasting the bile on her lips.

She had made a journey out to one of the further terminals. With the new operating system, she could effectively deliver the message from anywhere, but staying unpredictable would keep her alive for longer so she chose a different one each month.

With a simple plug into the terminal, she could access the data net and send her report. Nothing from the Bright Moon lot could be trusted anymore, but she had evidence of what Shadow Weaver was doing, a potential attempt to unite the goblin and merfolk clans against Halfmoon, and the battle plans of General Callix to take the city. But most importantly that Operation: Flight of Fancy was ready.

Her fingers hovered over the keyboard staring at the detailed report. She ran one hand over her face and it came away wet. Blinking the tears from her eyes, she began to type.

P.S. Due to the dangerous nature of Operation: Flight of Fancy, this will likely be my last report. The signal shall be given a few minutes before I can detonate the explosives, please do not let my sacrifice be in vain, it has been an honour to serve.

Halfmoon Stands,

Agent Blue

She closed the terminal with a faint click, powering it down, staring at the black glass of her reflection, haggard and exhausted from decades of war and lies. She could make this sacrifice for them, she would have to hope that Magenta was right. That would make this all worth it.

She avoided bots and patrols with the practiced ease of a lifetime of these nightly excursions. As she arrived back, she saw her squad was mostly asleep, a bunch of kids who had never seen

active duty. In her bunk, Thea slept peacefully. It had been six months since the stress drove her to seek a warm body to sleep next to, and she could mother the squad like her.

She gently nudged her awake, and the woman looked up at her eyes full of sleep. “Thea, I need to talk to you.” she whispered down to her.

“Can’t this wait until morning.” The woman turned her head into their pillow. “I just got to sleep. Jol and Spike started a fire while you were out.” She looked over at the two offending soldiers, snuggled up to each other like they needed to breathe each other's air to live.

She almost choked on her words as she said, “No Te, it can’t.” The woman turned to look at her.

“Shit, Sage. You okay?” She sat up immediately.

“Not really; we need to talk.” The woman pulled herself up, her pyjamas hanging loose over her shoulders. They were Sage’s pyjamas so of course they hung loose on the smaller Thea.

The two of them stepped into the bunkroom's bathroom, closing the door behind them. She leaned against the door, exhaling slowly. Thea sat on one of the toilets.

Sage looked at her, all frazzled hair and mismatched clothes and began. “I am going to talk and you’re just going to have to listen, okay?” The other woman nodded. “I know you were a spy for Salineas.” Thea looked shocked and opened her mouth to speak. “Darling, you’re not as subtle as you think.” She closed her mouth. “I am telling you this because, because… fuck.” She sank to the floor. “I am a spy, too. I am going to tell you the whole truth, something I haven’t done in thirty fucking years. I am a spy for the Kingdom of Halfmoon.”

“Halfmoon as in the Magicat Kingdom? Aren’t they all dead?”

"No. They fled to Subtheria. Since my early twenties, I have been a spy for them in this fucking place, feeding them intel, collecting data. I went through the entire Princesses' Alliance sending off my reports to a faction barely involved."

"Why are you telling me this now?"

"Because, I am about to do something stupid and reckless. Thirty years of doing nothing and suddenly it's all about to come crashing down." She wiped the tears from her face and in a blink Thea was there cupping her cheek. "I don't know if it will be tomorrow or the day after, but me and the rest of my cell have a big project coming up, one that's been in the works since just after you joined us. The chances of me making it are… Well, I just need to know that you will look after the kids."

"What are you planning? Maybe I can help?" She sounded so earnest.

"No, I can't tell you, all you need to know is it'll be big and it'll bring the whole damn Horde down on me. I won't live to see it finished, but I have changed the squads rota to work down in the hanger for the next week, and I've stashed a supply bag in one of lockers—locker 14C—for our squad. Just before it happens, I'll send you a signal. When it happens, I want you to take the squad and get out of here. Run, get to Salineas, hopefully they'll take you. Maybe Bright Moon, I hear they have training programs for defectors, just… please, I can't go through with this if you and them are in danger."

"Then why go through with it at all? Why put your life on the line for someone who's stayed out of the war for so long?" She was pleading with her to live. She had already made her choice.

"Because…" She hesitated to say it, to give voice to all her hopes and fears, but she had read what Magenta had sent. "Because if I don't the Horde will win, because despite all the darkness that surrounds me, I have faith. I've never shared it,

kept it buried under the pain of this job. But I do hold it so tightly I can feel it cutting my skin. I have faith."

"Faith? That's what's driving you to become a martyr for this cause?"

"I can't make you understand, Thea, just please, promise me. You'll get them out, get yourself out. Go to Salineas, find some nice girl and settle down, raise our kids. I need to hear you promise, maybe raise a drink for me once, something nice, then forget about me and live a full life. If I don't go through with this, the Horde will crush that dream."

Thea let out a shaky breath, tears in her own eyes. "Okay, I promise, at the first sign of trouble, I'll take the kids and go, I have some 'friends' in Seaworthy, it's closer and they owe me a solid. I am sure I can convince the kids not to go Horde on them just for existing outside of the Fright Zone." She was trying to laugh through the blubbering tears.

"Come on, let's go back to bed. I can't promise any more than one more night together. So just, hold me please?"

I will not order you to accept this risk, We may be marching to our deaths, but if we succeed, we will be legends. We will have marched into the Fright Zone to rescue our missing daughter. The khia'tel *of my daughter, the Princess, struck the first blow in our true retaliation against the Horde.*

I am not ordering, I am asking. The time for us to strike has come. An opportunity will present itself shortly. If we do not seize it, it will pass like a bird in flight. So, I am asking you to stand with me and march to the gates of hell itself. Who is with me?

-Transcript of a brief speech given by King-Consort Cyrus of Halfmoon to the Rangers of Halfmoon.

Horde R&D Department

The Main Horde Compound

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Two-and-a-Half Years After Adora's Abduction

"Try it now?" Kyle's voice called out. "The cabling should hold the voltage for a few minutes at least."

Amber flicked the switch and watched the readouts. It fluctuated for a moment, then the power seemed to settle. She kept a running tab on how it was working; the last attempt had lasted for eight minutes before collapsing and shorting out the entire system.

"Looks good, get up here." Kyle emerged from under the power bank, she handed him a rag so he could wipe the grime from his face. Once he had wiped himself down, she handed him a canteen with an extra water ration. "Now the quiet part of just watching the readouts. What's your bet?"

He took the canteen and a long swig. Over the last few weeks he'd been getting more exhausted, making simple mistakes, and unlike usual was quiet. She had called him here for an easy job, the kind of mindless work he wouldn't need to worry his head about. "Thirteen minutes. With the new cabling, the charge should hold but Lord Hordak is still putting way too much power into it." He leaned back, taking swigs from the canteen.

"Do you want to talk about it?"

"The insulation? You didn't read the technical readouts?"

"No, whatever's got you down. Everyone's seen it." He suddenly was staring at the ceiling. "You don't have to, just the

rest of the team is worried about you."

He sighed and looked at her. She could see he was just a kid really, barely out of his teenage years. "It's Lonnie. She's been getting worse. Ever since… ever since Rogelio went MIA. She's been getting more and more aggressive. She doesn't sleep well. I don't sleep well, either, and then she keeps looking to Shadow Weaver for approval, as if that old—" he cut himself off before he could say anything treasonous against the old witch. "I just wish she would look somewhere else for that affection." He means himself, she can't help but think. "Shadow Weaver is so much water wasted on sand, she just soaks it all up and gives nothing back. But Lonnie can't see that, she's just so twisted up about Adora and I mean I get it, Adora is loved by everyone she meets, she's like a sister to me, but she was gone for so long and the three of us had to suffer for it. Now she's back and Shadow Weaver's just tossed Lonnie aside like an out of date ration bar."

She nodded, trying to understand the complicated relationship between the Horde's second-in-command and her wards, of which both the Knight Captain and the VIP were supposedly raised by her, except Adora had been raised in Halfmoon. So many questions, her only interaction with the sorceress was through propaganda posters and the hurried reports she had read from Blue. It seemed like the three of them had survived under the most brutal childhood possible on Etheria; no wonder they were all a mess. Kyle's anxiety would never have worked in the field, and for that she was grateful that the Knight had reassigned him to R&D if only to keep him safe.

"That's rough, buddy. What are you gonna do?" She kept staring at the readout as her tablet chimed.

Message sent, we are green to go. Keep on your toes. Is everything green there? She read it twice before responding with an affirmative. Everything had been checked, she had planted the bombs herself and hidden them well. Manual detonation was required because of the insulation the forge had from the rest of the Fright Zone, but they all knew the risks.

"I just don't know. She keeps getting worse and nothing I say will knock some sense into her, she gets so focused on a goal, and if Ro where here maybe he could talk her down but I just, fuck, I don't know…" he trailed off into silence. Eventually, he put his head in his hands and screamed.

She just let him get it out as she watched the readout. After a minute or so, he settled back down. "Ten minutes, we've broken the record" As she watched, the terminal screen flickered and the numbers began to go haywire. She read the numbers twice, not really comprehending what she was seeing. Grabbing a notepad and pen from the desk, she wrote out the formulae in front of herself. It was right, the maths on the screen was correct. "Kyle, look at that, you've got a better head for it than me, tell me I'm wrong."

He looked up from his misery, eyes running along the figures darting from one end of the screen to the other. "No, that can't be right," he muttered. She handed him the paper, he looked down at it. "Is Lord Hordak planning to blow up half the planet? Why would he need this much power?"

"Some kind of superweapon to take down the Rebellion?" she asked, fear gripping her heart like a vice. They had just sent their last report off, discovering something new now would be disastrous.

"No, the power read is wrong." He typed something in, and a nearby printer whirred to life. "It's a power source for something unstable. A weapon with this much power draw might blow up our half of Etheria before it hit anything Princess owned." He grabbed the printed readouts, and stared at them, the fog of exhaustion clearing from his red rimmed eyes. He typed something else into the terminal, and a bunch of equations well beyond Amber's understanding flickered across the screen.

She tried to read them, follow the charts and graphs, but it was difficult. She got one thing though, "Is that some kind of teleporter, like a really, really big one?"

Kyle nodded. “It’s a portal, a huge amount of power draw, all to create a walk-in teleporter, but the coordinates are weird.” She squinted at the numbers and tried to map out where that was.

“Is that on one of the moons? No it’s too far, Hordak’s trying to teleport into the void?” Kyle didn’t comment on the lack of honourific. “This is way beyond our clearance level to know.”

Kyle just stared at it in growing horror, his mind running the calculations again and again. He suddenly lurched into action, turning off everything. The room was plunged into silence.

“If that ever activates, it’s likely to take the entire Fright Zone with it.” He couldn't keep the nerves from his shaking voice. “I don’t, I don’t know what to do with this.”

“We need to tell someone.” Her tablet buzzed—she ignored it.

“Who? All of the top brass report to Lord Hordak, he must have seen these calculations, this is mad, we’re gonna die.”

She hesitated for a moment. “The Princesses?”

His head snapped to her. “What!?” As he shouted, her tablet buzzed a second time. She needed to convince him. This was too important, she would need to tell Halfmoon, or Bright Moon, or somebody.

“We get out, head someplace we can lay low, then take this to Bright Moon, see about telling someone who can stop this from happening. Surely if they’re so powerful, they’ll need to know!”

“Amber, have you gone crazy we can’t just lea—”

Multiple power conduit failures reported throughout sector 4-19 due to overwhelming power draw from the R&D projects experiments. We have acquired insulated cables that should reduce overall power draw and will be attempting the tests tomorrow.

As soon as the completed results are in, we will send them directly to you, Lord Hordak.

Your Eternal Servant,

Researcher Kyle, Elite Squad Alpha

Dark Temple Quarters

The Main Horde Compound

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Two-and-a-Half Years After Adora's Abduction

The journey from the *tenemos* to her and Adora's quarters was a short walk but it felt like it took hours. Scorpia came to find the floor not swept and the chore rota completely ignored. She still shook with nerves about what she was going to do, what she was doing.

Shadow Weaver had come into the *tenemos* full of fury and had taken Adora. The witch had been infuriated by keeping secrets and Adora's progress had terrified her. Lonnie had said so once she had told Adora that "She's afraid of us" It was a memory that Adora had cherished. Now, her sister was in danger and that couldn't be allowed.

She made her way out of the *tenemos* so she could send the message to that woman who claimed to know Adora. She sent a single message.

Shadow Weaver has taken her, we need to move now!

She waited anxiously. Champions ambled past her and every second that passed, she could feel her panic rising. Finally, after what felt like hours but couldn't have been longer than a minute…

Acknowledged, It will take fifteen minutes. Good luck.

She stared down at that message. She had just asked a woman to die for Adora. They had been clear on that part of the plan. This woman, Blue, who's name she didn't even know, was walking to her death to rescue Adora.

She wouldn't let her sacrifice be in vain. She walked slowly back to gather her gear, and in a few minutes she was at the shared bunk. Gathering her mace and her armour, she grabbed two backpacks, and filled them with as many supplies as she could manage. Extra water rations, a change of clothes for both of them, a dozen ration bars leaving the rest of the Dark Temple with only brown ones. As she shouldered the backpacks, the entire building shook. The communicator on her chest suddenly exploded with voices. Duncan would meet her as soon as the explosions started.

She turned towards the Black Garnet chamber, and hardened her resolve. People would die to see Adora free, she would ensure it wasn't only those trying to help.

The whole thing just erupted into chaos. No one was sure what was happening, and it started before the attack. Whoever those cat hybrids were, they arrived after the explosion.

-Transcript of an interviewed soldier's after action report.

Quartermaster's Office

The Main Horde Compound

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Two-and-a-Half Years After Adora's Abduction

Sage sat there waiting for the sound of the explosions. Her hands barely shook as she poured another shot of cheap, stolen whiskey into a glass. Whoever knew the truth would be coming for her, either alone or with a squad backing them up. She had no intention of being taken alive or sober.

The blaster sat on the table, standard issue and with enough charge that a clean shot would blow a hole through all but the heaviest of Horde armour. She had always only been a decent enough shot to pass basic training. She finished pouring the drink into a tiny tin cup, almost half the bottle gone in the last day. She had a gut feeling it would be today when she woke up this morning, confirmed by the message she had received from Blue forwarded from Force Captain Scorpia.

Now she was just waiting for everything to come tumbling down like bricks in a wall hit by a mortar that would inevitably crush her. Raising the glass to her lips, she downed the burning liquid. The door slid open and in stepped Rose. Jisea Arach was a heavy infantry woman who supposedly had family in Bright Moon which is why she was willing to help. Apparently, like everything they did, it was a complete lie.

"Can I help you, Sergeant Arach?" She didn't stand or even really look at her.

"Where's the bomb, Sage?" Her voice was a snarl. No one else entered; she had come alone to find her. The one edge that they had always had over the Horde's intelligence units was their desire for glory, to prove themselves and win a position up the ranks. So that meant doing things solo unless ordered otherwise.

"Bombs are special request only. Do you have a demolition expert to sign off on it?" She was trying for humour. Jisea just drew her pistol from her belt.

"I will not ask you a second time!" she snarled. "You're going to help me find the bombs you have planted or I swear to Lord Hordak I will turn you over to Vultak and his cronies to do with as

he pleases. They're busy at the moment with one of your secret other cell members that we caught."

"Just admitting it, alright. You won't get an answer from me, Horde scum," she spat a gob of whiskey-filled saliva onto the floor next to the soldier who stepped backwards in disgust. "You're already too late to stop it."

"You were so easy to infiltrate. I have the names of all of you, everyone in your squad, and the others squads will be ripped apart. Half of us worked for the Horde, Me and Viren both worked for the Inspector. You never suspected a damn thing." She laughed at that. Viren wasn't a traitor, he was a triple agent, she had figured him out six months ago and cornered him, put a blaster to his head and demanded the truth. He was one of the last agents of Salineas who went by the codename of Knots only he and someone called Depths had escaped Operation: Seahorse, then he had been working with both organizations for years.

Sage laughed. "You think it matters? There are hundreds of us. If we die today, you will still lose, the Horde is going to eat itself alive because people like you think you can win."

"People like me?"

"Cruel, vindictive, you cannot lead, you cannot rule. You just destroy." She grabbed the tin glass and slammed all the drink down her throat. "You'll destroy yourselves before it's over, and even though I'll be dead and gone, you'll hear me laughing." She let herself laugh then, with all her belly. She was going mad with grief and anger.

Rose's annoyance was clear on her sneering face. "You have no idea what you are talking about. Now answer my damn question," she raised her pistol up to point at Sage, "Where! Is! The! Bomb!?"

"You won't find it," she laughed. "You're going to fail, and then you're going to have to report your failure to your bosses. And I'll

be laughing the entire stars-damned time.” She lunged then, grabbing the blaster from the table.

Her vision wobbled and she fired, the blast hit Jisea in her heavily armoured shoulder burning a huge score in the side. But it was a miss from the clean shot to the head she had intended. Jisea was on her in a heartbeat, slamming the pistol into the side of her head with a sickening *crunch*.

She fell backwards bleeding but kept the blaster in her hand. Jisea was on top of her slamming armoured fist and butt of her pistol into her over and over again.

“Where is it!?” she screamed in her face, which was quickly getting smeared with blood from her nose and scalp. She looked up into the face of her murderer and spat a gobbet of blood right into her eye.

Another fist to her head slammed it into the table and she fell in a pile. The blaster lay just beyond her reach. Jisea looked down at her, then her eyes went wide. “The indorium forge… Thats why you asked Viren to look into the production quotas, you were looking for a weak spot.”

Her mouth was full of blood. She spat some onto the floor then looked up, with not an ounce of fear on her face “You’ll never stop it.” She lunged for the blaster. The bolt caught her in the side of the head.

She was dead before she could hit the floor, and the door to the room burst open as Jisea ran to the forge.

> Notification of Death

> Quartermaster Sage Breaker

> Time of Death 03:00 EST on ||.||.||||

>Subject was found in the early hours of the morning by visiting cadets who broke protocol to steal additional rations for their squad. The quartermaster had suffered significant blood loss via blunt force trauma. Cause of death was a blaster bolt discharged at short range significant enough to cause instantaneous cerebral liquefaction. Additional toxicology reports show that the victim was significantly poisoned via a low grade recreational poison that was deemed irrelevant to the cause of death. The assailant remains unknown.

>Security camera footage of the quartermaster's storehouse had been intentionally cut and seems not to have worked for the past several months, attempts at reconstruction are ongoing.

>The cadets who reported this event have been reprimanded for being out past curfew with one week of half rations.

Medical Facility Backrooms

The Main Horde Compound

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Two-and-a-Half Years After Adora's Abduction

When he awoke, he was in an absolute nightmare from his worst moments, strapped to a medical gurney in the primary hospital of the Fright Zone, one of the rooms with soundproof walls and far away from where soldiers recuperated from their wounds.

It was a few hours ago, he was returning from a successful supply drop when he had run into a medic, the man had accused him of treason, and pulled a gun on him, the two of them had fought. Then he felt the pain in his neck where the needle had gone in. He tried to shake the stiffness out of his head but his

joints and neck were secured tightly in place with straps. Only his mouth and eyes were free.

A voice behind him, cold and deep, said “He’s awake.”

Another voice shrill and that sent a shiver down his spine responded “Good, I do not have the patience to wait on your concoctions.” That voice was one he recognised. Mortella, the daughter of Shadow Weaver. A sadist in the extreme. She stepped around into view. Her face was thunderous with anger. “I do not even have time to enjoy myself as I should. I could have had all day with you instead I will have to resolve this quickly.” Her hands moved in a long and complicated arch, glowing blue runes filled the air. “This is a truth spell, answer wrong and it will cause immense pain. Answer correctly but hesitate and Vandel here will cause great pain. Your answers will determine how painful your death will be, because make no mistake. You are dying on this table as your little rebellion falls apart.”

He grunted at her, snarling through his clenched teeth “I will tell you nothing witch!” The blade cut into the tendon of his arm swiftly cutting through the muscle and flesh down to the cartilage in one smooth practiced motion. A scream broke free from his lungs and reverberated off the walls.

“Tut, you will speak only when spoken to, and only to answer questions. Is that understood?” He glared at her, clamping his mouth shut. He would bite out his own tongue before giving them answers. Something dug into his neck, a needle sticking into a vein. He blinked as his vision began to collapse.

“That wasn’t an answer, very well onto the main questions. Who do you work for?” He wouldn’t give them anything except his screams, his mouth opened “I serve the Horde” it wasn’t technically a lie, he had killed many people in Hordak’s name. He would not reveal Halfmoon.

The woman hummed, her voice growing deeper as whatever was injected did it’s work. “What is your goal?” his head lolled, his

goal, fuck he was barely involved. Something about a VIP.

"I was asked to find a person, she went missing." he needed to wake up, focus and give them nothing else.

"And who was this person?" She held his chin with his hands.

"Ado—" He started to say and then bit down on his tongue, hard, whatever drugs they had given him had fucked with his survival instincts, his mouth suddenly washed full of blood.

"Adora?" She questioned, "Nod if you can understand me."

He nodded, blood dribbling down his chin.

The woman suddenly had magic coiling around her, rage emanating a raw heat. She turned to the man on her right, the medic he had lost the fight too, a nasty bruise was still on the side of the mans face. He looked at her and said "That means Force Captain Scorpia is part of this network. I'll get a team to arrest her."

She nodded "See to it." she turned back to him, picking up a blade. His world went dark.

The interrogation was a failure. I am certain the boy was a servant of the mongrels down in Halfmoon, but his adamance was admirable. A shame I could not have longer with him. Next time you catch one of them, please, Mother, allow me to work on them for as long as I wish. I will make those cats sing.

-An unsent message from Mortella to Shadow Weaver

The Forge

The Main Horde Compound

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Two-and-a-Half Years After Adora's Abduction

The forge was always a chaotic mess, production quotas being as high as they were. Things went out of place all the time. Combine that with scrap collection bots that would trundle around the place, and a work force on double or often triple shifts, many of them slaves. It was a recipe for the perfect place to hide out.

Amylin's authority had got her in; a sergeant had at least enough rank to get past the slaves, rookies, and bots to get inside. She had then snuck past the more aware security into the depths of the forge towards the great reactor that powered the vast industrial machines.

It was there that things got difficult. Her first obstacle had been a guard outside the door to the inner compound. He was clearly bored—these long shifts were exhausting, especially at home where no one would dare attack. The main job of the forge guard was to keep the slaves from taking too long a break. She used his distraction against him. She couldn't just pickpocket his keycard to get inside, if he noticed anything it would be over before it could begin.

Amylin slipped her belt knife out of her pocket and crept behind a box nearby, waiting for a slave to trip. He stood to shout at them to get back to work, at which point she darted out. With a single quick thrust, she pushed the blade through a soft spot in the armour at the top of the spine. He spasmed once. She caught him before he could topple and make too much noise, dragging his body to a supply crate and grabbing his keys. The first obstacle was down.

The second major obstacle was how to detonate the bombs. Mist had hidden the bombs made by the mysterious assassin all over the forge—after confirming their efficacy, how one man could get so much explosive power out of so little supplies must be

some kind of magic—unfortunately she had connected them to one supply request terminal.

The terminal was currently in use, and she had no time to wait. A single foreman was typing away filling out request forms. He hadn't noticed her enter, he only acknowledged her presence in the last moments of his life when the barrel of her blaster was pushed against the back of his head and he froze. She pulled the trigger before he could say anything. She rolled his body to one side and began to type.

Plugging in the special access device that Mist had given her, the overwrite system showed the option to begin detonation or to set a countdown timer. She typed out 15 minutes; she would need to keep it safe until then. Before she hit enter, she sent one final message, using the full strength of the terminal to somewhere far below Etheria's surface. It would take them that long to organize an offensive, they had been waiting for this moment. Today it would all be worth it. She started the countdown, cradling her blaster in one of her hands. With the other she sent the signal to Thea; she had to have faith that she would escape.

Amilyin's body trembled with nerves. She tried to walk them off, pacing the length of the room back and forth, keeping a careful count of the minutes. Ten minutes—six hundred seconds. She checked the charge on her blaster. Walked to one end of the room, turned in a march style and marched back.

Eight minutes. She rolled the body of the dead clerk over, and checked his identity card. A middle manager, he worked with the slaves. She would sound the alarm with a minute left, she decided, get the slaves out. Too late for anyone to stop it, just enough time to get most of them away.

Five minutes. She heard shouting outside, a scream, someone had found the body of the guard. She shoved a crate of the heavy metals up against the door to act as cover. If the Horde came blasting through, she would have a few moments at least.

Four minutes and the alarm sounded, people fleeing the danger. Over the internal comms on the foreman's badge, she could hear the cries for a ‘demolitions expert.’ Someone had found one of the bombs. They wouldn’t be able to find all the explosives in time. Even now, if they had captured Mist and Scorpia, they would have needed to start ten minutes ago to stop all of them. Sure, they might be able to disable one or two but the devastation would still be catastrophic.

It was at the three minute mark someone burst down the door. Rather than opening it to find the blockage, they simply placed a breaching charge, and blew the whole thing wide open. An incredibly risky move considering the amount of flammable and explosive material in the forge. She expected a squad to come bursting through, instead it was one soldier, heavily armed and armoured save for a massive burn on the right shoulder where the armour had been seared down to the joint. The figure attempted to close the distance, quickly. Amylin fired three shots in rapid succession which slowed but didn’t stop the figure.

Before the figure could reach her, she ducked backwards behind a small crate, barely big enough to cover her, slamming another charge pack into place. The figure leapt over the crate crashing down in front of her. She held the blaster up and fired one shot, clean like she’d practiced a hundred times, straight into the shoulder. It burnt through the weakened armour and the smell of cooking meat struck the air.

She fired again, this one for the helmet, which absorbed the blow but knocked it loose. The figure brought their gauntleted fist round into Amylin’s gut. She retched as the blow threw her back against the crate, she felt something in her shoulder pop as she fell to the ground, the blaster skidded away. She barely had time to roll away as a booted foot lashed out towards her, instead of striking her head it hit the shoulder already in agony.

With her good hand, she reached for her knife. It felt like a good, heavy weight, she jammed it into the joint of the knee. The voice inside screamed in pain. She leapt up, throwing her full

weight at the soldier who fell backwards against the floor with a thunk, the soldier's own pistol scattered off over towards the entrance. She tried to move away, throwing herself backwards to grab her own gun, or the soldier's. If this came to a fist fight, she was going to lose. She scrambled across the floor. The wet schlicking sound of a knife being pulled out of flesh followed by a groan of pain told her what was happening behind her.

She would need both her arms for this. She rolled onto her back and turned out the dislocated arm, screaming in agony as she rotated it and with a sickening pop went back into place. Her vision briefly went white with pain flashing behind her eyes. If she lived to meet another medic, they would surely complain about her method, but well… ninety seconds, if that.

The other figure had stood up, leaning heavily against the wall right next to the terminal. They had wrenched off their helmet which had been deformed by the hit. It was a woman, one she had recognised from her reconnaissance, the agent known in Bright Moon as Rose. Her red hair was messy around her head as sweat slicked her brow. It looked like before the fight she had sprinted across half the Fright Zone.

The woman was one of Grizzlor's heavy infantry specialists, trained to clear out towns in tank attacks, and used to close quarters fighting. In her hands, she cradled a heavy calibre pistol like a child. She had recovered it from the floor before standing.

Amilyn's own hands shook around the barrel of her own gun, the charge half spent. She brought the gun up taking a steadying breath. The woman, Rose, just laughed at her. Her arm was still trembling in pain.

Her laughter cut off abruptly. "Who do you work for?" she aimed cleanly at her, her arm as steady as a rock. "It's the one part of the puzzle I don't have."

Amylin just glared at her. "You don't know anything."

Rose laughed. “I have been working on dismantling the Bright Moon cell for nearly three years. When they contacted you, it took months to extract where the new information was coming from. But as soon as I found out, I also found out that you wanted to rescue that bitch that the Knight Captain and Shadow Weaver are obsessed over. But why is my question?”

She couldn’t keep the shocked expression off her face. No wonder the plan had to step up. If they found out someone was trying to extract the VIP, it would be a nightmare.

“Your face says I am right, but who do you report to? It’s not Bright Moon, we ruled out Snows when we got the regents on side, Salineas has no one left in the Horde according to all our intel and even if you were from them, what does one fucking girl who’s good with a sword matter to that guild of merchants? Blowing up a building to save one life might be a Plumerian trait, but I don’t think they could maintain the lie for as long as you have. So, are you from Dryl? One of the minor principalities?”

She could feel the countdown in her head. Ten…

“You’ll never know.” Nine…

Eight. The woman shrugged.

“Eh, worth a shot.” Seven…

The round hit her squarely in the torso and threw her off her feet. She fell against the wall, choking for breath. Six… Five…

She looked up at the woman, her murderer, and laughed… Four… Three…

“What are you smiling about?” Two…

“Halfmoon Sta—” One…

For one brief, glorious instant that lasted less than the blink of an eye, her murderer stood in absolute shock, before the

explosion annihilated both of them.

Last Message.

This is Agent Blue, sending an emergency broadcast to Halfmoon on an open channel. My clearance code is 12D05W2024. Operation: Flight of Fancy is a go. This will be my last message. You have fifteen minutes as of the delivery of this message to organize your attack after which the distraction is ongoing. You will have this one opportunity to extract the VIP. Several good folk have given their lives to see this operation complete—do not waste them. I do not count myself among the good folk but this will be my final message.

Now and always, Halfmoon Stands.

-Emergency transmission sent by Sergeant Amylin "Blue" Waters to King Cyrus of Halfmoon. Confirmed deceased during the following events, she was posthumously awarded the Star of Halfmoon for her valour in Operation: Flight of Fancy.

Near the Black Garnet Chamber

The Main Horde Compound

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Two-and-a-Half Years After Adora's Abduction

The fighting had been intense. From the first detonation, Scorpia and Duncan had rushed out to try and reach the Black Garnet chamber. At first, there was just confusion but upon seeing the prisoner loose and Scorpia standing next to him armed and armoured, well, it didn't take long for the soldiers to realize what was happening, by which point it was already too late.

Duncan was every bit the legendary warrior she had heard. He moved with all the fluid grace that she had seen in the *tenemos* but with the added lethality that his great, crushing mace could bring to bear. It was lighter than her own; only a two dozen pounds of metal which he could swing with enough force to crack Horde armour like an egg.

The Fright Zone was in absolute chaos which the two of them could use to their advantage. They fought when they had to and simply ran through confused troops when they could. The firefights against Horde soldiers were intense, a barrage of fire which she would walk through with Duncan taking cover behind her carapace from which he would chuck the occasional grenade, all precisely placed to blow holes in the Horde formation.

Despite their skill, it was like trying to fight through a wall of steel with your bare pincers. The Horde, despite all their flaws, were soldiers first and foremost and when they realized they were under attack, they rallied, ready to defend themselves. Squads formed into natural choke points laid into the very architecture of the Fright Zone. Scorpia knew these halls as well as any of them, Duncan had his instincts for war that kept the two of them from being shot apart by heavy weapons teams but kept dragging them further and further from their goal as they had to avoid tanks and mortars and heavy weapons teams that could break even her hard carapace apart.

They had to use stealth as often as violence, getting as close as they could to the Black Garnet chamber, near the heart of the Fright Zone. It was as they got closer to their goal, towards Adora, that things started to go wrong. The sky above them crackled with lightning as a great storm roiled overhead. She could feel it, a pulsing of magic, all coming from the chamber ahead, and if she could feel it, every sorcerer on Etheria could feel it…

The two of them rounded a corner to only a short sprint to reach the chamber, kill Shadow Weaver and rescue Adora. But, as

they got around, between them and safety was a squad of troops, heavily armed. Three stood out.

The first was Mortella—she had several Shards hanging from her robes and was wreathed in dark arcane power. Next to her standing tall was Grizzlor, the only person in the Horde who could match Scorpia strength in a wrestle. Behind them leading the squad was a sergeant rallying the troops. He wore the uniform of a medic but Scorpia could recognise him for what he was, a torturer.

Duncan hefted his mace. "Princess, get to Lady Adora. I'll handle the witch and the brute and catch up with you as soon as I can. **For the honor of Greyskull!"** There was no time to argue. The soldiers were already firing.

She charged, shoulder checking Grizzlor who attempted to grab her. Anyone else in the Horde grabbed by Grizzlor was almost certainly dead but she sent him stumbling back as she crashed into the line of troops. Behind her, she heard the mad shrieking of Mortella, furious at Duncan, at her, and Adora. She could channel all the dark magic her Shards would grant her to kill them all but the Master of Arms of Eternos was free and he would never be chained again.

The squad before her were skilled, part of the elite of the heart of the Horde, well trained warriors meant to defend the Fright Zone itself from Princess attacks. But most Princesses used magic to fight, and so their armour was enchanted to ward off spells and the elements, not two hundred pounds of crushing force swung by muscle that could lift a skiff without straining.

These were soldiers who had chosen, unlike many others. They had seen all the cruelty of the Horde and had chosen to serve Shadow Weaver directly. The Medic pulled out some vial—a poisonous gas. He went to throw it at her. With a rapid swing of her tail, his body went limp. She picked him and the vial up in one claw by the neck before he could fall, and tossed him across the length of the corridor. He crumpled in a pile fifty feet away and

the vial cracked. His eyes, the only things not hit by her venom, went wide as his skin began to flake and peel, acid filling the air around him.

As he fell, there was a great shaking followed by a *boom*. Ahead of them, the sky split and a thousand lances of lightning crashed down on the Black Garnet chamber. From inside, she could see golden light flecked with darkness pouring out of the hole like a burst pipe.

Behind her, the fighting was intense. Multiple explosions rained around the area as Duncan drained through the last of his supplies, and vicious coiling tendrils of magic danced across the ground, but the Master of Arms was dancing between them. For all his prodigious strength, Grizzlor could not land a single blow upon the warrior, and he had long since learned many of Mortella's tricks. He may not be able to avoid them forever, but certainly long enough to make her suffer.

Before she could move back to help him, she could hear screaming coming from within the Black Garnet chamber. The warriors around her were trying desperately to strike at her. She would need to be quick and trust that Duncan would live. She struck out like the Warrior Princess she was at the guardians of the Black Garnet chamber, breaking bones, throwing bodies, her tail a natural part of her injected so much venom into her foes that she was feeling woozy. Three dozen guards had faced her; less than eight remained.

The elite warriors had faced Princesses, they claimed they knew no fear, but now, they ran, breaking from the woman they would call traitor and the magical light that would overwhelm their defences. The path of the Black Garnet stood open before her.

Under confession, a member of the Halfmoon intelligence confessed to having planned the attack. The recorded interrogation can be found below and in my report of the events of that day. Most shockingly, however, was the previously thought

to be loyal Princess Scorpia was revealed to have betrayed the Horde in pursuit of rescuing the wayward girl, Adora.

This act of vile treachery cannot go unpunished. However, revealing her survival of the events may destabilise Lord Hordak's claim to legitimacy as Emperor of the Nest. We have two options presented to us: we can either organize her assassination wherever she arrives, or we can denounce her as the culprit of the explosions in a failed attempt to assassinate Lord Hordak and assume the throne herself. As a precaution, my recommendation is to begin both. We cannot have the Scorpioni doubting Lord Hordak's will.

I will begin preparations at once. I await your response, Mother.

-A report sent by Mortella to Shadow Weaver three days after the bombing of the forge.

Horde R&D Department

The Main Horde Compound

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Two-and-a-Half Years After Adora's Abduction

Amber coughed away the dust and opened her eyes against the glare of light outside. Outside… The explosives had gone off; why hadn't she been warned? The resulting blast had thrown chunks of debris high into the air, thousands of tonnes of molten rock and shards of metal, one of which had collided with the building she was standing in. She looked around still shaking off the shock of the moment when she remembered.

"KYLE!" she screamed out. Fuck, where was he…? She scrambled forward towards where he had been standing. The whole wall had tumbled downwards on top of him. She began to claw away digging into the rubble.

She had dug through rubble like this before. Those were unpleasant memories of before she came to the Horde, the very organisation that had left her scrambling through rocks looking for her brother and finding only dead meat. She hoped against all hope that this time was different, that she hadn't killed another person she cared about with her misadventures.

She heard an exhale of breath, and a groan from somewhere to her left and she shifted her digging to there, careful to not crush anyone underneath or to displace a block that would cause a cascade down onto both of them. It was meticulous and slow work, taking minutes when she might only have seconds.

If the bombs were set off early, it must be because the Horde got to someone. That means Amylin is already gone. She knew pragmatically if she stayed to pull Kyle out, the odds of her escaping the Fright Zone decreased dramatically for each wasted minute. However, if so many people were giving their lives today, then at least she would make sure Kyle lived, get him out of here to tell the Princesses what was coming.

She shifted a large piece of metal to spot him. He was lying down on his back, a large gash across his temple was bleeding profusely. But he was breathing, even groaning in pain. She took great care to pull him out, settling him against a wall. She rushed into an undamaged room as sirens wailed around her and grabbed a medical kit. She had done field first aid, same as everyone in the Horde.

By the time she got back, he had stirred, gently touching his hand to the bleeding wound with a distinct lack of suprise—surviving under Shadow Weaver makes anyone tough. He looked up at her and mouthed a 'Thank you.'

She set down the supplies and began searching through. Grabbing antiseptic and stitches, she set to work. He grimaced only slightly when the needle went in, waiting until she was halfway done before he asked, “What happened?”

She pulled the stitch taut. “Explosion at the forge, a big one.” She tried to sound clinical. “We’re under attack, I think.” She cut the excess—the stitching would hold. She grabbed a ration bar from her stash, he would need the calories to replace the blood loss.

“Who would attack the Fright Zone directly?”

She hesitated for a moment. “Kyle, I need you to trust me. Can you do that?”

He looked at her, mouth hovering over the ration bar. He put it down and looked her in the eyes. “Amber, I trust you. But please tell me what the fuck is going on?”

She stared at him. *Fuck it, I might be the last one alive and we need to get out of here.* “It’s Adora’s family.”

He stared at her like she had grown a second head. “Adora’s an orphan like me and Lonnie…” he muttered.

“She may well be, but I work for a group called Halfmoon, it’s the kingdom of the Magicats. I don’t know how to reach it before you ask. But I helped them build and plant a bunch of bombs. They’re a distraction so they can rescue Adora from whatever the fuck Shadow Weaver has planned for her.” She sounded desperate even to her own ears.

“You’re a traitor to the Horde?!” He tried to push himself up against the wall.

“Kyle, listen to me. We still need to tell someone about this,” she gestured at the destroyed computer equipment, which was sparking dangerously. “If we don't, Hordak is going to blow up half the planet in his mad quest to conquer the world.”

"Then you go and tell them, I can't stop you." He had slid back down the wall and was clutching his head.

"I can't, I won't, not without you."

"Why?" his voice came out strangled.

"Because she's only going to get worse. Both of them, if the group succeed, then Adora will be gone, and that will leave Shadow Weaver furious. I'll certainly be killed as a traitor, and Shadow Weaver's ire will turn on Lonnie, which will then be turned on you. If Shadow Weaver succeeds then Lonnie will be cast aside, another broken tool in the Fright Zone's repertoire of broken fucking tools. You'll go down with her."

His next words were so quiet she had to strain to hear them over the sirens. "But I love her." The quiet whisper was a lead weight dropped into the room.

She knelt down next to him. "I know you do, but this can't go on, and it's bigger than both of us. If you stay, they'll drag you down. If you leave, we might be able to get her out as well. Anything out there has got to be better than in here, right?"

He looked up at her, eyes wet with tears. The man had always been sensitive, breaking the first and only rule of the Horde. "I have access keys to the engineers' cargo carrier, which I've stashed some gear on. We can get out of here before the confusion settles." He looked up at her eyes still wet, then he nodded. He stood on shaky legs and walked over to his desk. He grabbed a notepad and began to write something. A note she could see, addressed to Lonnie. She would likely come to check here. She went to grab her supplies and gave him a minute of privacy.

When she returned, he gave her one look, grabbing a collected bag and sealing the small letter into an envelope, on top of which he left a small stitch of cloth, a shooting star behind a fortress.

Dear Lonnie,

I am sorry. I wish I could stay, but this is too big. You're being torn apart and you're too hurt to see it. I wish it had gone differently. Perhaps, in another lifetime, we'd be happy and safe; you, me, and Ro. But we live in the Fright Zone—nobody gets a happy ending here.

Somethings come up, something too big to handle, and I need to warn the world. If that makes me a traitor, then I am sorry. But she showed us that sometimes being a hero means making a sacrifice. I miss Rogelio more than anything right now, he'd know what to say.

Do not look for me.

Love, now and always,

Kyle

Blasted Wastes

Horde Outskirts

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Two-and-a-Half Years After Adora's Abduction

The squad was halfway out of the blasted wasteland between the edge of the Fright Zone proper and the blasted wasteland that was once Scorpioni territory that made up the no man's land no rebel had yet to cross. The skiff journey with the six of them was barely questioned by any of the kids and when she looked at them really they were just kids, all dressed up in uniforms, but not a single one was older than eighteen. Her own daughter had only had her seventeenth birthday a few months ago, not that she

even knew what a birthday was. Another thing the Horde had robbed from these children.

Thea just did as Sage had ordered them when they awoke this morning. She had sent them down to grab the skiff and head to one of the further outposts and to get ready that morning packing everything they would need including sentimentals, saying they were being transferred. So it was that it was a whole minute after the explosion went off—for a moment there was an extra daymoon in the sky—that they actually heard it, all of them but Thea turning back to stare at it in mute horror.

"We're under attack." Miner's voice was shocked. "Who would dare attack the Fright Zone?"

"We have to go back," Jolene said, turning to her. "Sarge is back there."

A silence fell over the skiff for a moment, when Thalassa looked up at her. "Mom, why are you crying?" Nearly all of them turned to stare at her.

She couldn't stop the tears from falling. Sage was dead, everything had fallen apart, and there was nothing she could do. "We're continuing on," she breathed out. "But we're going past the outpost. We're leaving the Fright Zone"

"What?!" all of them but Spike shouted. The lizardfolk just kept staring back, he had in his hands a standard issue set of binoculars, as the group's scout he had the sharpest eyes.

"We cannot go back to the Fright Zone." She blinked away tears. "I am so sorry, but we can't."

"Why not?!" they cried in unison.

"Because both Sarge and I are wanted traitors!" she spat it out, anger coiling in her voice. The kids were all stunned into silence. She let out a shaky breath. "If we go back, we all die!"

The silence was oppressive save for the hum of the engine and the very distant sounds of the aftershock of the explosives. Spike broke it after a minute. [[Someone else is leaving,]] he pointed and in the distance squinting she could see another small skiff leaving and heading north, towards the Crimson Waste. More deserters, good for them taking their chance. He paused for a moment, then raised the binoculars back up. [[Someone's teleported in. That's the battle signal for an invasion, not an accident.]]

He turned to face her, his lizard features expressionless. Five accusing faces, and she just wanted to curl up into a ball and weep for everything she had given for this mission but for now she had to keep driving.

After a moment she spoke again. "The Sarge and I both work for the Princesses." She stated it factually. "I work for Salineas, the Sarge, well, she never told me who. But it was her plan to cause that." She gestured at the still burning building, keeping one hand on the Skiff controls. "She activated it manually." They all turned a shade paler at that. "My only goal now is to make sure you five stay alive. If that means you throw me off this transport and turn it around to say you've killed a traitor then so be it." She closed her eyes and waited. When no grabbing hands, swung knives, or discharged blasters hit her she opened them. They were just staring at her in shock. "In honesty, if you go back, they will kill you for being associated with traitors. Trust me, I know. I am calling in a favour I am owed to get all six of us a safe place to stay in Salineas, together. I am not letting us get separated." They looked to her, then at each other, clutching each other, or the meagre possessions they had thought to pack this morning. She would keep them safe.

She promised her that much at least. She would keep that promise, even if it was the last thing she ever did.

Jolene crawled over to lie against Spike and Scatter looked up at her, their big doe-like eyes of the fawn staring at her. "Which

way to Salineas?” they asked after a moment. She pointed. “Sit. I’ll drive, you rest.”

The skiff floated across the rocky terrain unopposed, crossing past the rocky crags until they hit the shore. She turned east towards Darkport, from there she reckoned she could charter a ship somewhere safer, like Seaworthy. It was only when they stopped for the night that her daughter approached her, tears in her own eyes and wanting to ask “Why?” that she pulled her into a hug and wept for everything she had lost. The night was one of tears, but of a new beginning. She would not squander it, that would be the only sin she could commit now.

Operation: Flight of Fancy After Action Report

The cost of this endeavour has been severe. While I understand the necessity, we are now without our primary assets within the Horde. Attempts to introduce or co-opt other networks will likely take years of work. All for very little intelligence gained.

The operation itself had marginal military benefits. The destruction of Horde Indorium Production was a key victory, for which I am recommending Agent Blue—full name Amylin Water—be awarded the Star of Halfmoon, for without her efforts then this excursion would be a complete failure.

We are currently unable to identify the whereabouts of Temple Daughter Adora. The VIP went missing at some point during the raid, though we have it on good authority from a trustworthy source that she has escaped the Fright Zone alongside a new ally in the form of the now renegade Princess of the Nest, Scorpia. We now must trust to hope that she will return to us via one of the few available paths.

In summary, the loss of life for this venture has been catastrophic, with a complete loss of our intelligence operatives within the Horde as well as the volunteers who lost their lives that day.

Amylin Waters "Blue" - KIA

Sharps Fort "Tail" - KIA

Amber Regard "Mist" - MIA

Halfmoon Stands.

-A letter sent from Halfmoon head of intelligence to Queen Lyra and King Cyrus about the Bombing of the Forge and Operation: Flight of Fancy.

My Lord Hordak,

I apologize for the oversight. While our attention was focused on Bright Moon and its operatives in the Horde, it seems Shadow Weaver allowed a few mongrels to slip their cage in the dark and break into the Horde. If I was made more aware of the nature of Shadow Weaver's project, perhaps I could better protect the Horde.

Rest assured the results have been taken care of, with only a minimal loss of Horde Intelligence assets. We have confirmed the deaths of two cells working counter to the Horde's most glorious mission. The first group we have confirmed were in allegiance with Bright Moon, and while I would have preferred them kept alive, we have found them all killed due to the unfortunate events of the battle. They consisted of Sergeant Sage Breaker, codenamed Azure, and Private Ample Moonless, codenamed Magenta, and Alpha Squad's own Kyle of Research and Development, codenamed Brains. A second cell was in allegiance with the city of Halfmoon, which I was assured by Shadow Weaver personally were incapable of threatening us with spies. They consisted of Captain Amylin Waters, codenamed Blue, Sergeant Sharps Fort, codenamed Tails, and Researcher Amber Regard, codenamed Mist.

Of these six names, I can confirm the death of four of them. The other two—both Kyle and Amber—are missing in action,

though they may still be buried under the ruins of Research and Development. I shall have my inspectors keep an eye out for any word of these two across Etheria.

I shall see to it nothing like this happens again.

Glory be to Hordak and the Horde,

Spymaster Darkney

-A letter sent from the spymaster of the Horde to Lord Hordak detailing the events from his perceptive.

Catcher,

I have been transferred away and my letters may take longer to reach you. The bear was slain and with it my duty and I have been sent to the sea to hunt a mighty beast of the waves. Such a feat may take me many months if not years but now I will think of you every waking moment.

I shall try to send you letters when I can, but know no matter how long it is you do not hear from me, that I long to return to you with a prize worthy of you.

Kindest Love,

Cyan

-A Coded message delivered to Netossa one week after the Bombing of the Forge.

To the head of the Salinean Intelligence Bureau,

Thank you for the accommodations and for being so understanding. It is taking a while for it to get settled. I would ask for patience for the kids and leniency if any crimes are committed before by or against them. I understand tensions run high but please, they are good kids.

The pay packet for my time in the Horde has been sufficient to get us all settled. I thank you for the generous wage and severance package and ask nothing more for myself, but to be able to hold a commemorative burial for those that we lost. I feel like we could all do with some closure.

In the future, I ask you not to contact my children for a debriefing as they are skittish enough as is. If you wish to speak to any of us, feel free to send someone along to talk at the bar, in private.

I can provide a list of names who may be sympathetic, but until such time as my children are settled, I am unwilling to put them in further danger. Perhaps in a few months I can make the journey to the city proper.

Kind Regards,

Thea of Old Waters.

-A letter sent from Thea to the Salinean Intelligence bureau from her tavern on the outskirts of Seaworthy. Six Months post the Bombing of the Forge.

End Notes

This is mainly to fill in the interim and deal with the fact that we couldn't have Lonnie turn on the Horde like cannon, so all these OCs got invented just to die. But I snuck some old woman yuri in their as a little treat to you and me.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!